

First Read

China Insurance Sector

The need-to-know: insurance fund flow, sales, and investor feedback on stock performance

Equities

China
Insurance

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Sector equity exposure rose QoQ in Q126, despite weak stock market

NFRA recently released [Q126 industry statistics](#). Insurance fund AUM was +2.5% QoQ to Rmb39.4 tn, as (1) steady cash inflow driven by solid premium growth (+6.2% YoY) was partially offset by (2) fair value loss on equity and bond investments. Equity was the fastest-growing asset class. Exposure to long-term equity stake trended up 0.2 pp QoQ to 7.8%. Stocks and securities investment funds accounted for 16% of AUM, +0.1 pp QoQ, likely reflecting the (1) bottom-fishing move, and (2) business mix shift towards PAR products. Allocation to bonds was +0.1 pp QoQ to 51%, as insurers capitalized on the rise of long-dated bond yield. Exposure to 'others' (mainly non-standard debt assets) and bank deposits declined, down 0.3 pp/0.1 pp QoQ to 18%/8.1%, extending the trends seen in previous years, as the maturity of higher-yielding assets coincided with supply shortage. In 2026, insurers generally expect interest rate to hover at a low level, according to Q1 earnings calls. Many also indicated that the current asset class allocations were at appropriate level.

YoY growth of FYRP moderated in Q2-to-date – not a surprise

For most listed insurers, YoY growth of first-year regular premium (FYRP) moderated in Q2-to-date, not a surprise, as (1) deposit maturities/migrations were concentrated in Q1 this year, (2) insurers are preparing for [bancassurance regulatory change](#) (i.e. Circular 65) effective from Jul, and (3) comparable base is tougher in Q2. Circular 65 demands a more granular approach in reporting of expenses and cost allocation. While the rectification process facilitates a healthier industry development, it may lead to lower actual sales incentives, suppressing bancassurance sales. In Q2-to-date, CPIC outperforms in FYRP growth (UBS-e), as the insurer changes bancassurance product strategy and strives to catch up peers. China Life also fares better than most peers in sales, but we expect YoY margin expansion to narrow in rest of the year vs Q1. Ping An faces growth pressure in Q2-to-date, as the company upholds a more disciplined approach in commission consistency following regulatory scrutiny. In H2, the key debate is centered around bancassurance - regulations would be tightened after Circular 65, but the level of enforcement is uncertain following the changes of NFRA leadership.

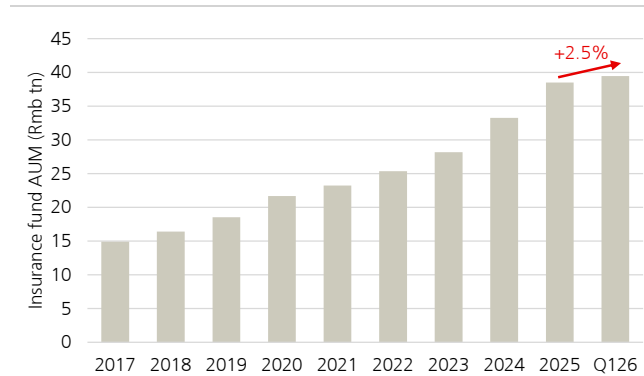
Investor feedback on recent share price performance

Equity market rebounds in Q2-to-date, bringing expectation for strong earnings recovery for insurers, especially life names, in Q226 – assuming a stable equity market performance in rest of the quarter. China life insurance sector (H/A), however, fell by 5.3%/ 8.7% over the past week, lagging Hang Seng Index/CSI300 by 2.5 pp/6.3 pp. We gather investor feedback: From fundamental perspective, some investors are concerned about the tougher comparable base for VNB from June, given the buying spree before pricing interest rate cut at end Aug-2025. Further, A-share life names underperformed H-shares by 20 pp in YTD, possibly due to (1) reduced A-share insurance exposure by 'national team', and (2) sector rotation towards tech in A-share market (CSI Tech 50 +8.8%/STAR 50 +27%; vs Hang Seng Tech: down 12%), and (3) increased holdings of insurance (H) by insurance funds (e.g. Ping An continued to invest in China Life-H).

Stock calls: China Life (2628.HK) & Ping An (2318.HK)

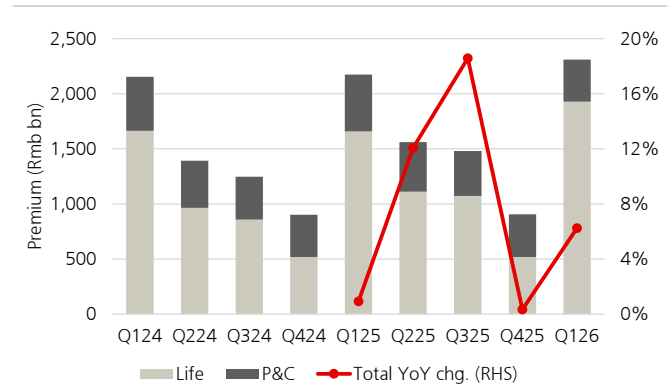
We like China Life (H), given its (1) relatively high earnings sensitivity to equity price and beta, (2) above-average FYRP growth in Q2-to-date, and (3) low base for earnings in Q2. 72% of its stocks were classified as FVTPL as of 2025 (vs peers' average: 57%). We also like Ping An (H) for its (1) sustained double-digit VNB and group OPAT growth in 2026E, and (2) attractive dividend yield of 5.3% and valuation of 6.1x P/OPAT (12M FWD).

Figure 1: China's insurance fund AUM expanded by 2.5% QoQ to Rmb39.4 tn...



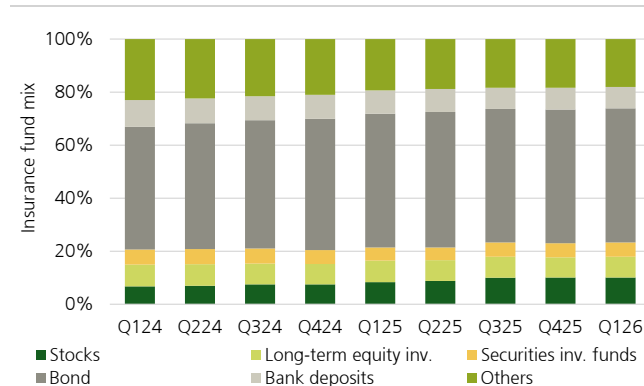
Source: NFRA, UBS.

Figure 2: ...partly driven by solid premium growth (+6.2% YoY)



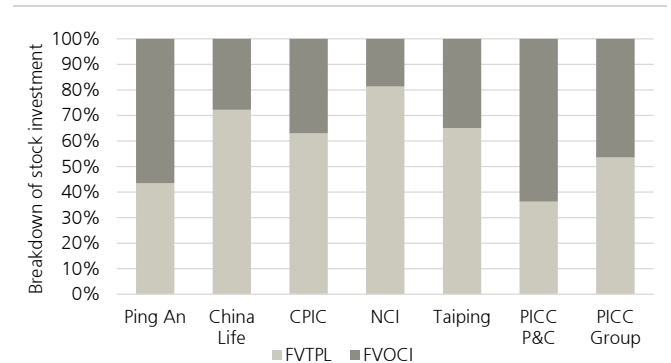
Source: NFRA, UBS. Premium

Figure 3: Equity was the fastest-growing asset class in Q126



Source: NFRA, UBS.

Figure 4: 72% of China Life's stocks were classified as FVTPL as of 2025 (vs peers' average: 57%)



Source: Company data, UBS.

Valuation Method and Risk Statement

Our price target for China Life is based on appraisal value methodology.

Our price target for Ping An is based on SOTP methodology.

Investment risks for China insurance industry include: 1) equity market downturn; 2) prolonged interest rate down-cycle; and 3) worse-than-expected operating experience variance.

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Neutral	FSR is between -6% and 6% of the MRA.	40%	21%
Sell	FSR is > 6% below the MRA.	6%	21%

Source: UBS. Rating allocations are as of 31 March 2026.

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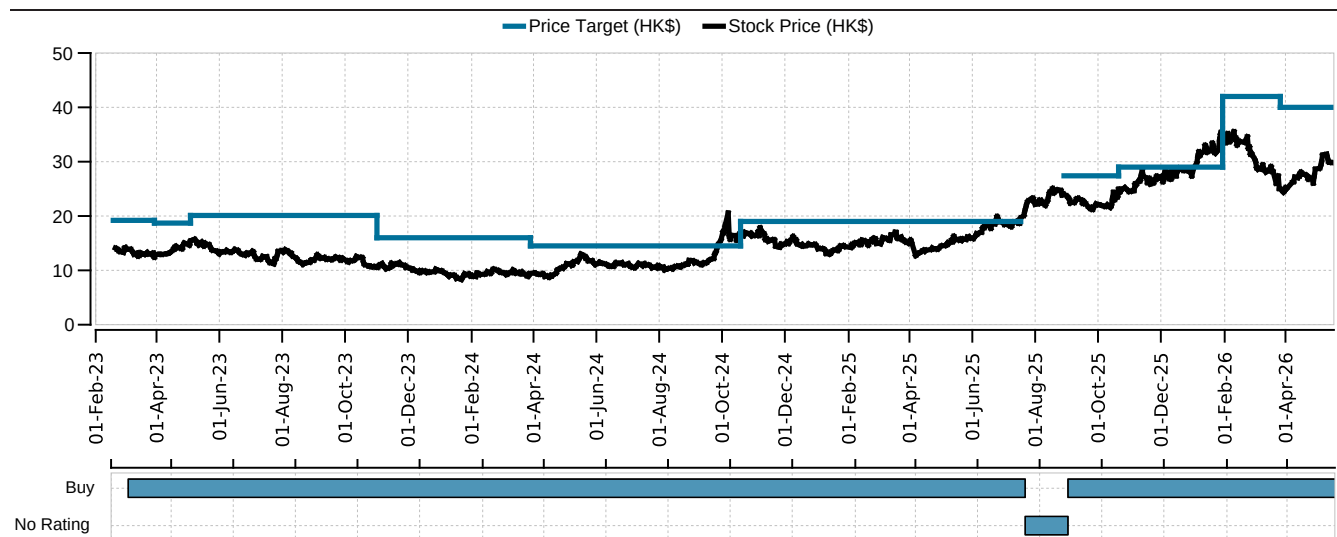
Company Name	Reuters	12-month rating	Price	Price date
China Life Insurance ^{16,7,18a,6a,6b}	2628.HK	Buy	HK\$29.76	18 May 2026
Ping An Insurance (Group) ^{13,4,16,28,7,18a,6a,18b}	2318.HK	Buy	HK\$61.85	18 May 2026

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China Life Insurance (HK\$)

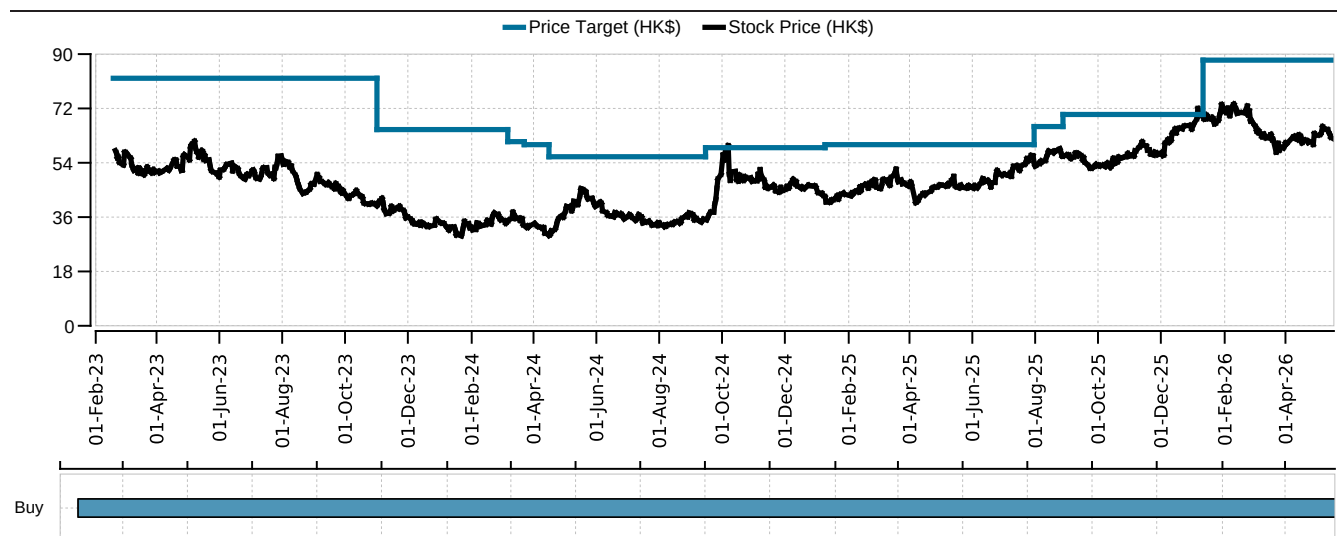


Date	Stock Price (HK\$)	Price Target (HK\$)	Rating
2023-02-17	13.52	19.20	Buy
2023-03-29	13.16	18.70	Buy
2023-05-03	14.64	20.10	Buy
2023-10-31	10.60	16.00	Buy
2024-03-28	9.39	14.50	Buy
2024-10-18	16.66	19.00	Buy
2025-07-17	18.70	-	No Rating
2025-08-28	23.92	27.40	Buy

Date	Stock Price (HK\$)	Price Target (HK\$)	Rating
2025-10-20	23.52	29.00	Buy
2026-01-29	35.52	42.00	Buy
2026-03-26	25.04	40.00	Buy

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon as of 18-May-2026. All prices as of local market close. Ratings as of date shown.

Ping An Insurance (Group) (HK\$)



Date	Stock Price (HK\$)	Price Target (HK\$)	Rating
2023-02-17	57.05	82.00	Buy
2023-10-31	40.10	65.00	Buy
2024-03-06	34.60	61.00	Buy
2024-03-22	33.45	60.00	Buy
2024-04-15	30.35	56.00	Buy
2024-09-14	35.35	59.00	Buy
2025-01-08	43.05	60.00	Buy
2025-07-30	56.30	66.00	Buy
2025-08-27	56.30	70.00	Buy
2026-01-10	70.00	88.00	Buy

Source: UBS Global Research; LSEG Eikon as of 18-May-2026. All prices as of local market close. Ratings as of date shown.

Additional Prices: Ping An Insurance (Group) - A, Rmb54.89 (18 May 2026); China Life Insurance - A, Rmb34.75 (18 May 2026); Source: UBS. All prices as of local market close.

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